

What's New For 2006

FROM A MAJOR Windows upgrade to powerful Web services to high-definition DVD, there's a lot to look forward to in the coming year. Here's a partial list—just two items—from the link mentioned below. Be sure to check out the page!

The approaching new year looks to be full of change for the way you work and play with technology. Among the exciting developments heralded for 2006: Advanced Web apps and tools will further blur the line between the desktop and the Internet. The next generation of DVD will arrive at long last, ushering in high-definition recording. Wide-screen LCD monitors will continue to become less expensive and more attractive, while new technologies will begin to boost display quality dramatically. And Microsoft will finally ship its long-awaited Windows Vista operating system.

But the road to these anticipated developments won't be without its share of jolting bumps and potholes. A standards battle is raging between next-generation DVD camps. Vista will require a pretty beefed-up system to run properly.

And most of the new monitor models will be priced (at least initially) beyond the means of all but the most well-heeled users. Treat this article as your one-stop guide to some of the hottest new technologies, so you can decide whether they'll be right for your tech needs in 2006.

Vista View: Microsoft's next major operating system looks a lot different from the Windows you're used to seeing. But the parts of it you can't see might be even more important. It has been just over ten years since Microsoft launched Windows 95 to great fanfare and hype (and the Rolling Stones' song "Start Me Up"). Now, as Microsoft prepares its next major operating system launch, scheduled roughly for the end of 2006, an appropriate theme song might be "Security" by blues siren Etta James. ...

Security isn't the only focal point of Windows Vista. Also included are additional gaming features, a stronger desktop search function, a reworking of the graphical user interface, compatibility with high-definition TV, and other multimedia tie-ins. What's more, Vista is the first mainstream operating system from Microsoft built to handle 64-bit applications. The new OS should combine with the latest CPUs to improve gaming, system performance, and security.

The Web's New Generation: Soon you'll enjoy amazing, lightweight Web sites that respond like desktop apps.

For most people, "going online" involves launching a browser and surfing to different Web sites. But recent advances in how Internet data interacts with the desktop have already begun to change our idea of "going online" radically, and the metamorphosis will continue in 2006.

As with any revolutionary technology, the advance has garnered a slew of names. Some call it Web 2.0. Others call it "Open API," alluding to the sharing of key programming code known as the application program interface. And many are calling it Ajax (for Asynchronous JavaScript and XML), after the coding technology that is changing the way browsers interact with Web data. But regardless of the name used, 2006 will see an outpouring of new Web applications that take advantage of it.

For the complete column, visit
www.pcworld.com/reviews/article/0,aid,122928,pg,4,00.asp

The Gift Of A Domain

MATT LAKE FINDS the perfect gift for a friend in the form of a nice, juicy presence on the Web...

When that huge box of chocolates arrived by courier, I knew I was in trouble. The large gold box told me right away it was Godiva. And the sender's address on the mailing label told me it was a gift from somebody I'd forgotten...

Just as the suitable reciprocal gift anxiety began setting in, an answer came to me: How about a domain? A nice, juicy presence on the Web for showcasing close-up photography of chocolates, cocoa-

related prose, and poetry—or anything else she felt like. And so I was off to the virtual market to make the purchase.

A day earlier, I read an opt-in e-mail newsletter from Dotster, one of the stable of registrars I rely on to

hold my collection of domains. The newsletter suggested giving a domain for the holidays, which I considered a dumb idea designed to squeeze one more domain registration from a desperate gift-giver. But that was before the chocolate. Now, I realized it was a brilliant idea designed to squeeze one more domain registration from a desperate gift-giver.

But what could I buy? The obvious back-slapping saucy joke domain, .xxx had already been deep-sixed from the agenda at a recent ICANN meeting. A nice .eu domain, also recently in the news, had a sophisticated, Continental sound to it, but not exactly a good match for this particular friend.

It would have to be a good old-fashioned dot-com domain. So I turned to the usual suspects. The company that had started me down this road, Dotster, had just announced a seasonal price drop of .com, .net, .org, .info, .us, and .biz domains from \$15 to \$6.99, good until the end of December. That's enough to bring out the bargain hunter in anybody.

Seven bucks in exchange for a box of Godiva seemed like a deal good enough to eat. But by the time I priced up the bargain hosting that plan Dotster offers (a good deal with free scripts for blogs, galleries and forums, 500MB of storage and 25GB transfer), I was way over the budget at \$71.40 for the year.

So I hopped over to one of the mainstays of all-in-one hosting: DirectNIC that offered a \$15 package with registration, ad-supported hosting, and e-mail forwarding. Was this gift worth giving? It had domain registration, a Web site and e-mail addresses. Still, I didn't have the time or the inspiration to slap a Web site or page on the site.

Then I remembered an opt-in mailing that GoDaddy had sent out last week. Recently, GoDaddy added a little sweetener to its ridiculously cheap domain registration package. For nine bucks, you get a domain, a solid POP and Web e-mailbox with a capacity of 25MB. The real kicker was the five-page starter Web site that came with its standard domain registrations. ...

Next followed twenty minutes on PayPal and the deed was done. I set up everything in my friend's name, except for keeping the primary e-mail address as my own to prevent a stray message from the company from spoiling her surprise.

For the complete column, visit
http://reviews.cnet.com/4520-6028_7-6401346.html

